Ford Motor Company

James P. Vondale, Director
Automotive Safety Office
Environmental & Safety Engineering

August 10, 2001

Mr. Kenneth N. Weinstein
Associate Administrator for Safety Assurance
National Highway Traffic Safety Administration
400 Seventh Street, S.W.
Washington, D.C. 20590

Dear Mr. Weinstein:

Re: Ford Recall No. 01S26 -- 1999-2001 Model Year Windstar Auxiliary A/C Blower Motor Resistor Wiring

Summary

- Ford Action -- Ford is conducting a voluntary safety recall to revise the wiring for the auxiliary (rear) A/C blower motor resistor on 1999-2001 model year Ford Windstar vehicles. These vehicles were built from April 16, 1998 through December 17, 2000.

- Number of Vehicles Involved -- Approximately 525,164 vehicles (approximately 413,245 in the U.S., 79,775 in Canada, and 21,668 in Mexico).

- Effect on Vehicle Operation -- If the auxiliary A/C blower motor stops turning due to a failed bearing or a foreign object restricting the blower wheel, and the switch is set in the medium low speed, the thermal limiter in the resistor assembly is not in the circuit as intended, which could allow overheating of the resistor and, potentially, smoke or a fire. To date, Ford is not aware of any reports of smoke or fire.

- Service Procedure -- Dealers will install a jumper wire to include the thermal limiter in the medium low blower speed circuit.

Attached is the detailed information required by the applicable portions of 49 CFR Part 573 -- Defect and Non-Compliance Information Report.

Sincerely,

James P. Vondale

Attachment
01S26 5d/rjw/ae

ATTACHMENT

49 CFR Part 573 -- DEFECT INFORMATION REPORT
01S65 – 1999-2001 MODEL YEAR WINDSTAR
AUXILIARY A/C BLOWER MOTOR RESISTOR WIRING

Pursuant to Part 573 of Title 49 of the Code of Federal Regulations, Defect and Noncompliance Reports, Ford Motor Company submits the following information concerning a safety recall action that it is voluntarily initiating. Although Ford has not determined that a defect trend exists, this action is being conducted at this time as a precaution.

573.5 (c) (2) -- Potentially Affected Vehicles

Certain 1999-2001 model year Ford Windstar vehicles built at the Oakville Assembly Plant from April 16, 1998 through December 17, 2000 and equipped with the auxiliary (rear) A/C system.

Because these vehicles are not produced in VIN order, information as to the applicability of this action to specific vehicles can best be obtained by either calling Ford's toll-free line (1-800-392-3673) or contacting a local Ford dealer, who can obtain specific information regarding the vehicles from the Ford On-line Automotive Service Information System (OASIS) database.

573.5 (c) (3) -- Estimated Population of Vehicles Potentially Affected

Approximately 413,245 vehicles.

573.5 (c) (4) -- Estimated Percentage of Affected Vehicles with the Defect Condition

Unknown.

573.5 (c) (5) -- Description of the Defect

If the auxiliary A/C blower motor stops turning due to a failed bearing or a foreign object restricting the blower wheel, and the switch is set in the medium low speed, the thermal limiter in the resistor assembly is not in the circuit as intended, which could allow overheating of the resistor and, potentially, smoke or a fire.

As of August 3, 2001, Ford is not aware of any reports of smoke or fire as a result of the subject condition. The wiring was not released as intended and Ford has decided, as a precaution, to conduct this action at this time.

573.5 (c) (6) -- Chronology of Events

Ford first began investigating this matter on November 14, 2000 when the supplier of the auxiliary climate control module reported that the medium low blower speed was not routed through the thermal limiter by the Ford released harness. A review of field data conducted during November did not locate any reports of smoke or fire related to the condition. Subsequent testing conducted during November 2000, December 2000, July 2001, and August 2001 verified that the condition could result in either smoke or a fire if the auxiliary blower was set to the medium low speed and the blower was prevented from turning.

573.5 (c) (8) -- Service Program

Owners of record of affected vehicles will be notified by first class mail to return vehicles to dealers for installation of a jumper wire to include the thermal limiter in the medium low blower speed circuit.

573.5 (c) (9) -- Press Statement and Dealer/Owner Letters

Ford does not plan to make a public statement concerning this action. Ford currently plans to begin notifying owners on or about the week of August 27, 2001.

573.5 (c) (11) -- Recall Number

Ford has assigned recall number 01S26 to this action.